

In the reading for today, Sider's aim is to present a paradox involving a series of claims which, from the point of view of standard views about judgement and the afterlife, seem quite plausible. Let's work through his reasoning.

1. **Non-universality**: some people go to heaven, and some to hell.
 2. **Divine control**: it is up to God who goes to heaven and who goes to hell.
 3. God sends some people (group A) to heaven and some people (group B) to hell. (1,2)
 4. **Badness**: people in hell are very, very much worse off than people in heaven.
 5. God makes group A much better off than group B. (3,4)
 6. **Proportionality**: justice prohibits very unequal treatment of persons who are very similar in relevant respects.
 7. **Justice**: God's judgement about who goes to heaven & hell is just.
 8. No one in group A is very similar in relevant respects to anyone in group B. (5,6,7)
 9. **Dichotomy**: there are exactly two states in the afterlife, heaven and hell.
-

C. There is some way of dividing all humans into two groups so that no member of one is very similar in relevant respects to any member of the other. (8,9)

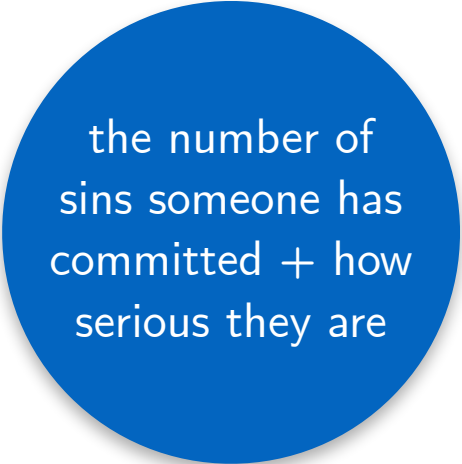
The problem, Sider thinks, is that there is no way of dividing up the population of people which avoids putting relevantly very similar people into different groups.

The most straightforward way to reply to the argument is to say that the conclusion of the argument is true. Then the question is: what are the relevant respects? What are the properties that God looks at to determine who goes to heaven and who to hell?

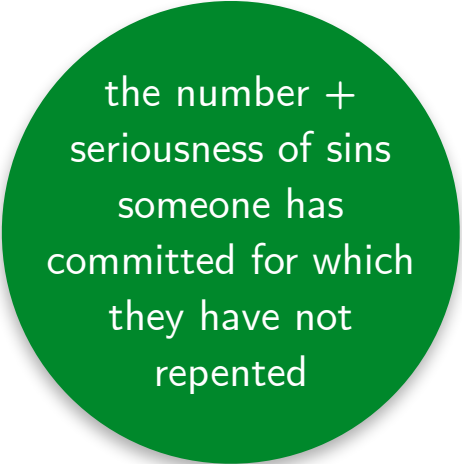
What could these properties be? Let's consider some possibilities.

A large, solid orange circle with a subtle drop shadow, centered on a white background. Inside the circle, the text "the number of sins someone has committed" is written in white, lowercase, sans-serif font, arranged in four lines.

the number of
sins someone has
committed



the number of
sins someone has
committed + how
serious they are

A large green circle with a subtle drop shadow is centered on a white background. Inside the circle, white text is arranged in six lines, centered horizontally.

the number +
seriousness of sins
someone has
committed for which
they have not
repented



the person's faith
and trust in God

Let's consider a different possibility. What if, when God encounters a borderline case of the relevant properties (whatever they are) God does not send the person to heaven or hell, and instead gives the person more time to determine whether they deserve to go to heaven or hell.

In the Catholic tradition, this is close to the idea that some people after death go to
neither heaven nor hell but rather to purgatory.

On the standard Catholic view, any who goes to purgatory eventually goes to heaven.

But then in deciding who goes to heaven, who to hell, and who to purgatory, God is deciding who eventually goes to heaven and who eventually goes to hell — which means that again we need some way of dividing the “borderline cases” from those who go to hell, and the problem is unsolved.

Could a different view of purgatory, on which some people in purgatory eventually go to hell, help?

It seems that he does. He is paying people very different hourly wages despite the fact that their relevant properties (the kind of work they were doing) was very similar.

The landowner seeks to argue that he is not as follows.

Does the Landowner violate Proportionality?

“The kingdom of heaven is like a landowner who went out early in the morning to hire men to work in his vineyard. He agreed to pay them a denarius for the day. About the third hour he went out and found some people in the marketplace doing nothing. He told them, “You also go and work in my vineyard and I will pay you what is right.” So they went. He went out again in the sixth hour and the ninth hour and did the same thing.

About the eleventh hour he went out and found still others standing around doing nothing. He asked them, “Why have you been standing around all day doing nothing?” “No one has hired us,” they replied. He said to them, “You also go and work in my vineyard.”

When evening came, the owner of the vineyard asked his foreman to call in the workers and pay them their wages, starting with the ones who were hired last. The workers who were hired about the eleventh hour each received a denarius. So those who were hired first expected to receive more. But each one of them also received a denarius.

When they received it, they began to grumble against the landowner, “These men who were hired last have worked only one hour, and you have made them equal to us who have worked in the heat all day.”

The landowner said, “Friend, I am not being unfair to you. Didn’t you agree to work for a denarius? Take your pay and go. I want to pay the people who were hired last the same as I paid you. Don’t I have the right to do what I want with my own money? Or are you envious because I am generous?”

Is the landowner unjust?

We have been exploring one kind of question about the afterlife: the question of whether a certain traditional conception of the afterlife is compatible with a perfectly good and just God.



the
paradox of
heaven and
hell



replies to the
paradox



evil & lives
not worth
living

But there is another important philosophical question about the afterlife, which is the question of whether the very idea of an afterlife makes sense. Given well-known facts about what happens to bodies after death and burial, how could it make sense to say that we might survive our death?

This is a question to which we'll return in the third section of the course.

In the reading for today, Sider's aim is to present a paradox involving a series of claims

quite plausible. Let's work through this reasoning.

which, from the point of standard views about judgment and the afterlife, seem



1. **Non-universality:** some people go to heaven, and some to hell.

otthier. (8,9)

derivatives.

6 **Proportionality**: justice prohibits every unequal treatment of persons

3. God sends some people (group A) to heaven and some people (group B)

member one is very similar in relevant respects to any member of the

There is one way of dividing all humans into two groups that

5. God makes group A much better off than group B. (3,4)

B. (B, O, R)

4. **Badness:** people in hell are very, very much worse off than people in

which are very similar in relevant respects.

to be ill. (I, as)



2 **Divine control:** it is up to God who gives to heaven and who goes to hell.

~Justice: God's judgement about who goes to heaven & hell is just.

8 Mon group A is very similar in relevant respects to any other group

9 **Dichotomy:** there are exactly two states in the afterlife, heaven and hell.

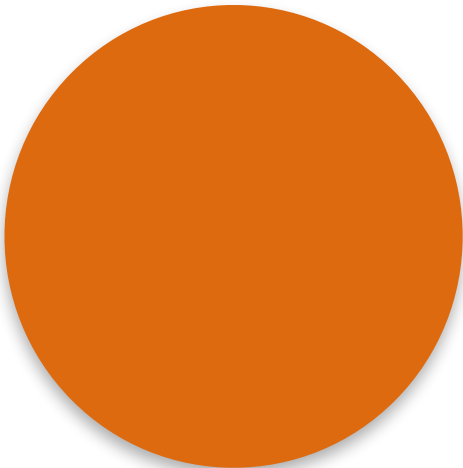
The problem, Sider thinks, is that there is no way of dividing up the population of

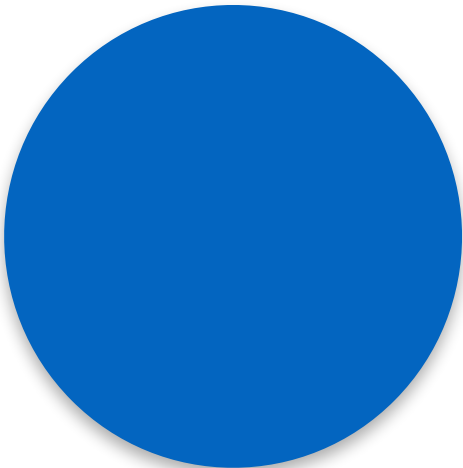
people who avoid putting relevantly similar people into different groups.

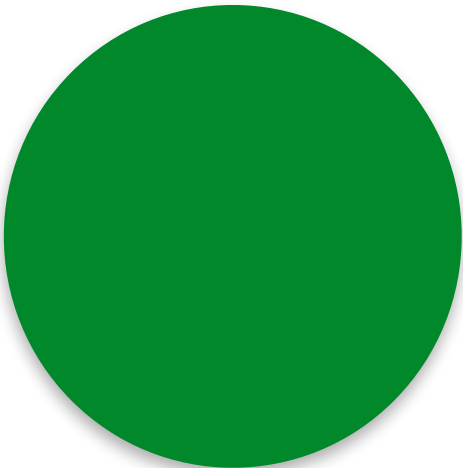
the argument is true. Then the question is: what are the relevant respects? What are the

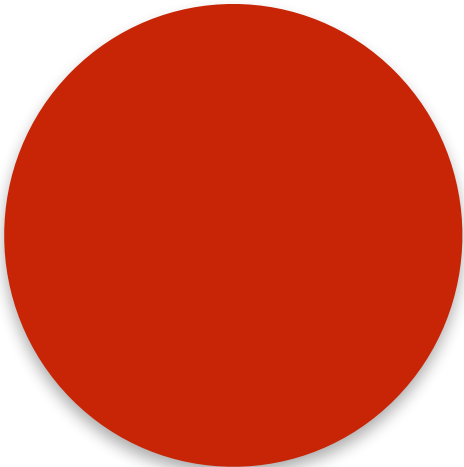
The most straightforward way to reply to the argument is to say that the conclusion of

properties that God looks at to determine who goes to heaven and who to hell?









the relevant properties (whatever they are) God does not send the person to heaven or

Let's consider a different possibility. What if, when God creates a borderline case of

hell, and instead gives the person more time to determine whether they deserve to go

to heaven or hell.

neither heaven nor hell but rather to purgatory.

In the Catholic tradition, this is close to the idea that some people after death go to

On the standard Catholic view, anyone who goes to purgatory eventually goes to heaven.

hence, and the problem is unsolved.

But then in deciding who goes to heaven, who to hell, and who to purgatory, God is

deciding whether eventually goes to hell — which means

that again we need some way of dividing the 'borderline cases' from those wh

Could a different view of purgatory, one which some people in purgatory eventually go to

hello, help?

It seems that he does. He is paying people very different hourly wages

despite the fact that their relevant properties (the kind of work they

were doing) was very similar.

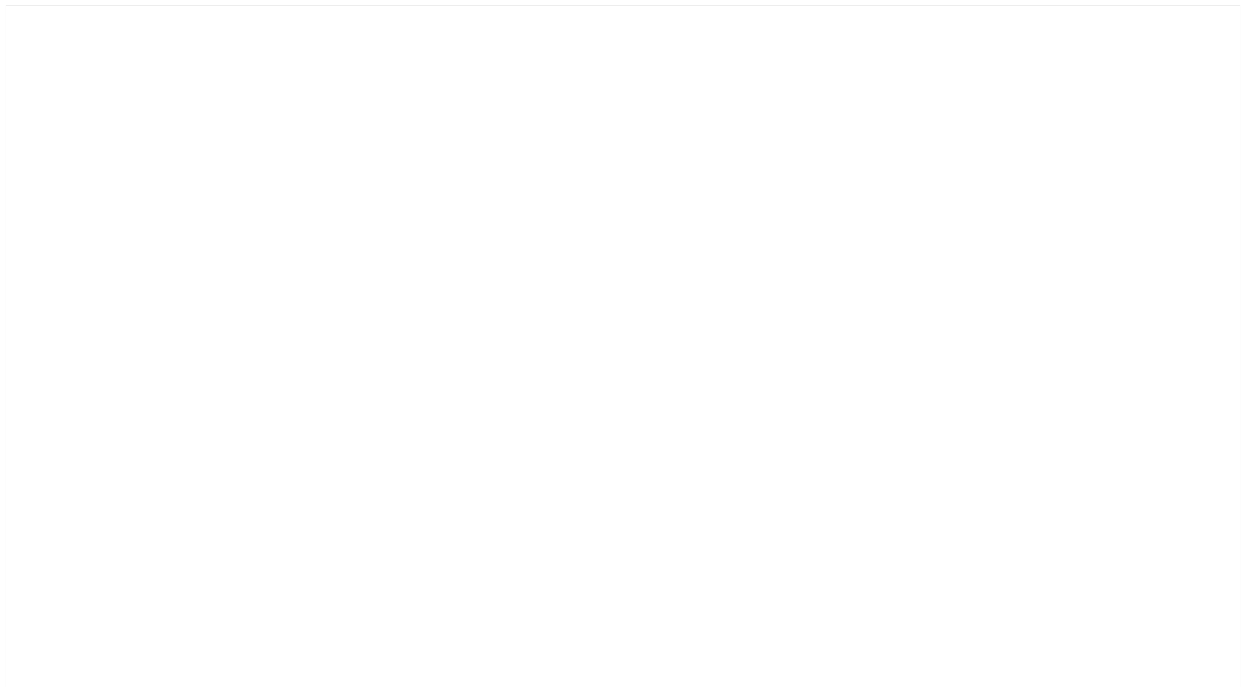
We have been exploring one kind of question about the afterlife: the

compatible with a perfectly good and just God.

question whether a certain traditional conception of the afterlife is

The following passage from the Catechism of the Catholic Church

describes the kind of view wanted to discuss:



1038. The resurrection of all the dead, 'of both the

the angels with him... Before him will be gathered

just and the unjust,' will precede the Last

Judgment. Christ will come "in his glory, and all

another as a shepherd separates the sheep from the

into external punishment, but the rights into

eternity!

goats, and he will place the sheep at his right hand,

but the goats at the left.... and they will go away

all the nations, and he will separate them one from

One topic often associated with belief in God is the topic of life after death.

Our first question today is: what we are told about life after death by

perfectly good Good?

many of the major monotheistic religions practiced with the existence of a



the Last Judgment. . . Christ will come "in

as a shepherd separates the sheep from the

this glory, and all the angels with him.

1038. The reservation of the dead, "of

both the just and the unjust," which preceded

and the wild sheep are then from another

right hand, but the goat at the left... and

goats, and the wild prairie sheep at his

they will go away into eternal punishment,

but the rights are all in it.

Before him will be gathered all the nations,

This certainly seems like a picture according to which, after death, God passes

judgement on all of us, and on the basis of our life, decides that some of us will

talk of the last judgment wouldn't make much sense.)

got to heaven forever, and some others to hell forever. (If not 'forever', then the

Turned-in showed why it is plausible that respo to the argument from evil

must depend on the possibility of life after death. We will now ask: is the kind of

view of life after death we get here on pain of being perfectly good?





makes sense. Given well-known facts about what happens to bodies

But there is another important philosophical question about the

afterlife, which is the question of whether the very idea of an afterlife

after death and burial, how could it make sense to say that we might

Survive our death?

This is a question to which we'll return in the third section of the

COVERS.E.







evil & lives
not worth
living

Let's try to layout Sider's reasoning by isolating the various features of the

the existence of a perfectly good God.

traditional doctrine of heaven and hell that he thinks are inconsistent with

“A certain traditional conception of the afterlife is *binary*. After death one proceeds either to heaven or hell. Heaven is very, very good; hell is very, very bad. There are no possibilities for the afterlife other than heaven and hell, and membership in heaven or hell is never indeterminate or a matter of degree. The problem with the binary conception is that it contradicts God's justice. God must employ some criterion to decide who goes to heaven and who goes to hell. No reasonable criterion would be sharp; any reasonable criterion will have borderline cases. But the binary conception of the afterlife allows for no corresponding fuzziness in how the dead are to be treated. Hell must therefore contain people who are nearly indiscernible in relevant respects from people in Heaven. No just God would allow such a monstrously unfair thing.”

It is part of the traditional doctrine that God decides whether people go to

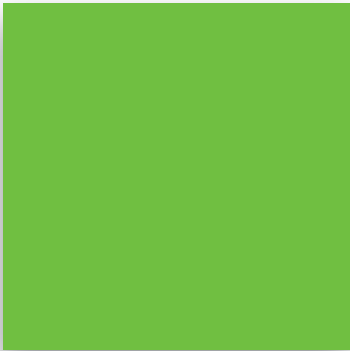
heaven and hell based on certain properties of these people. We will have

open for what those properties might be; just have a name for them,

Let's call them the relevant properties.



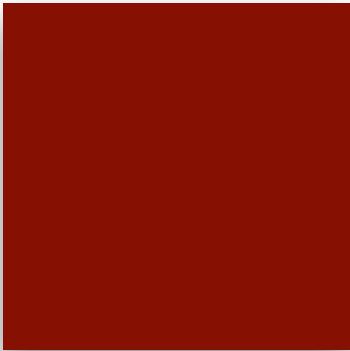










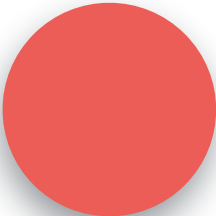


It seems difficult to deny Justice, Badness, or Divine Control. So that

seems to give the defender of the afterlife further main options.



replies to the
paradox





the
paradox of
heaven and
hell

